

Andy In Class By Himself

THREE WEEKS have passed since University of Texas at El Paso baseball coach Andy Cohen announced his resignation, but his office remains the same.

Every morning, dedicated Andy drives his UTEP/colored, orange and white Buick to the Special Events Center. When he arrives, as he has done for the past 16 years, Cohen promptly opens a large stack of letters from prospective baseball players.

It's no secret that Cohen has coached his last Miner baseball game, but still, the dean of the Western Athletic Conference baseball coaches has a long, lasting loyalty to the university. Nothing would give Cohen more pleasure than to leave an outstanding crop of players in the new coach's lap.

There are few people like Andy Cohen. He gives so much of himself and gets so little in return. UTEP paid Cohen peanuts to coach, but Cohen wanted it that way so his earnings wouldn't jeopardize his Social Security benefits.

Had Cohen never been here, baseball would have probably been a long time in coming. Along with his brother Sid, who offered his time for free, the two men built up the baseball program to a competitive level.

The Miners held their ground against opponents whose budgets dwarfed UTEP's. It was a shame UTEP had to take annual licking from the Arizona schools.

THERE WERE some good times for Cohen, comparable to the memory Andy has of winning his only game as a major league manager for Philadelphia on opening day in 1960.

"The biggest thrill was my first year. We had no scholarships and we were playing New Mexico which had captured the Rocky Mountain League the year before," Cohen said as he slit an envelope which contained a 26-page hand-written letter from a youngster in New York who had cerebral palsy but insisted he could play baseball.

"We beat New Mexico 7-6 and I can remember how thrilled the players were," added Cohen. "After that, the boys got wise. They wanted scholarships. I liked it with no scholarships because a coach could develop his own team and talent. That's when you could find out



Andy Cohen



Mark Leibson
Times sports writer

how good a coach can be."

The most pleasure Cohen received was avenging those humiliating losses to ASU and Arizona.

"Beating ASU, that was fun," Cohen said. "I remember little Mark Bombard was a big hero for us. We had them 4-3 in the last inning several years ago and Mark walked the first man. The next guy hit a little pop fly which fell behind the first baseman.

"ASU had runners on second and third with no outs. Mark got the next two batters out and I can remember who was up next, Roger Schmuck. What a name. The first time I met him, I broke out laughing. Right before our game, he was honored as the Athlete of the Year. He was their star slugger and Mark struck him out on three pitches. That was a super thrill.

"Also beating Arizona in a doubleheader last year and once this year. Bob Alsup turned in a Bombard-performance with his arm and his glove up in Tucson."

As the years passed for Cohen, his athletic capabilities diminished. He realized this past season that when he used the fungo bat to hit infield practice, his stroke lacked enough punch.

"I felt I didn't hit them hard enough. I could sense that," he said. "I like to hit fungos. I couldn't hit them hard enough for the kids to get something out of it."

COHEN'S ADVANCING age brought on more and more of a generation gap between Cohen and his players. Unlike some oldtimers who refused to change with the times, Andy stepped aside and allowed last year's team to grow long hair and beards.

"I just told the boys that 'Look, if you feel comfortable and keep them neat, go ahead and have a beard.' Look at the big leagues or the Diablos. I wasn't crazy about it but if it helped a kid be a better ball player, I was for it," Cohen said.

That's what Andy Cohen's life has been about for the past 16 years — helping kids who want to learn baseball. His current plans are to remain at UTEP to assure a smooth transition when the new man takes over.

"I'm trying to line up a good team for the new coach," Cohen said. "It would be a thrill to go out next season and see how a new coach does with the team."